

DANGER SIGNALS

The rapidly rising rate of smoking among urban Indian women makes them new victims of the tobacco scourge that, experts say, is ballooning into a major health crisis for the country

■ By Damayanti Datta

Time was when she walked hand-in-hand with her man on sun-kissed beaches, snuggled under the umbrella with him in pouring rain and woke him up every morning with a fresh cuppa and a sweet smile. The passionate witness to this made-for-each-other pulse of life—on billboards, print ads and the telly—was always a flaming cigarette. In the new millennium, the cigarette is spectator to new history. The urban Indian woman is now stepping out of that colourful world of commercial fantasy on to reality, but not as a passive inhaler accompanying a “man with the smooth edge”. She is now busy walking up the tobacco trail all on her own.

The smoking gap between men and women is getting narrower. One in 10 women smokes or chews tobacco in urban India today, says a new World Health Organisation (WHO) study, First Report on Global Tobacco Use. Over 31 per cent women between age 15 and 49 use tobacco in some form or the other, shows the latest National Family Health Survey—a steep hike from 10 per cent in 1995-96. “Across the world, more women are taking to tobacco,” says Bhavani Thyagarajan, joint secretary and the woman in charge of the National Tobacco Control programme under the Union Ministry of Health. “In India, the percentage may be a small fraction of the total, but it’s large in absolute numbers.”

The trend is eye-catchingly evident to the veterans. Ask Samita Sen, who heads Women’s Studies at Jadavpur University in Kolkata. Sen remembers those days in the ’80s when, as a student of Presidency College, her upfront smoking had raised hackles among quite a few male students. “There were several attempts to discipline me and other women smokers, though those finally didn’t add up to much.” Today she marvels at the blatant intensity

with which girls smoke around the campus. “At one time, I used to be the sole woman customer of my neighbourhood cigarettemallah. Today there are so many of us.”

But in a country, where “good girls” still don’t smoke, the increasing feminisation of cigarettes poses a unique challenge. New research points to new crisis that goes beyond taboos and stigmas. In a hushed but unrelenting manner, tobacco-related diseases are engulfing the fairer gender, snuffing out lives and taking away productive years. The first nationally-representative study of smoking in India, conducted by a team of 900 field workers from India, Canada and Britain and published in the *New England Journal of Medicine (NEJM)* in February 2008 estimates that over 62 per cent Indian women smokers will die in their productive years compared to 38 per cent of non-smokers. Over 20 per cent are at the risk of getting respiratory diseases, 12 per cent heart attacks, and 9 per cent tuberculosis. “Alcohol consumption has been found to affect women more in comparison to men. In the same way, tobacco damages women more,” reports the lead author of the study, Prabhat Jha. One in 20 of all female deaths in India between age 30 and 69 will be caused by smoking in the 2010s, he predicts.

Surveys suggest that since the ’90s, more women than men have started smoking in the crucial adolescent years when smoking careers are established. A 2006 study by the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) on over 6,000 students across 32 schools in Delhi and Chennai showed, 20 per cent sixth standard girls are lighting up. Another 2006 survey from Delhi University’s Patel Chest Institute found college girls smoking seven times more and 87 per cent just for fun. In an alarming corollary, the *NEJM* study reports that fewer women than men are calling quits in later life. In fact, lung cancer has surpassed breast cancer as the leading cause of death among women since 1987.

of women who smoke die in their prime compared to **38%** of those who don't

1 out of 20 women in India to die between age **30-69** due to tobacco in the 2010s

Source: WHO First Report on Global Tobacco Use, 2008; NEJM 2008; NFHS India 2007; Tobacco Atlas 2006; Report on Tobacco Control in India 2005